

Aksharaa Bhobe

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Consumer insights and brand strategy professional with agency experience leading end-to-end qualitative and quantitative research across technology and CPG, among other categories. Turns ambiguous business questions into rigorous research designs, pairing segmentation and survey analysis with ethnography, in-depth interviews, and phenomenological analysis to guide brand and product growth strategy. MS candidate at Northwestern Medill (GPA 3.93), graduating December 2026.

EDUCATION

Northwestern University, Medill School of Journalism — MS, Integrated Marketing Communication Expected Dec 2026
GPA: 3.93 | Selected as Grader, IMC 401 Consumer Insight (Fall 2026)

FLAME University — Postgraduate Diploma, Interdisciplinary Studies and Research (FLAME Scholars Program) 2022 – 2023
GPA: 8.47/10; Academic Merit Scholarship

FLAME University — BBA, Communications Management 2019 – 2022
Class Rank: 2/46 | GPA: 8.5/10 | Silver Medal (2022); Dean's Roll of Honor, all semesters

EXPERIENCE

Third Eye Integrated Services — Mumbai, India Aug 2023 – Apr 2025
Clients include Google, Mondelez (Cadbury Gems), Amazon, Vivo, Piramal, L'Oréal, Sprite, Bayer

Senior Research Associate Apr 2024 – Apr 2025

- Translated ambiguous client briefs and RFPs into research approaches and proposals; independently led 20+ mixed-methods studies across CPG, tech, beauty, and finance, owning scope, client communication, quality, budgets, and timelines.
- Ran immersions with SMB owners to learn why they chose social and marketplace tools over Google's search-based ads, surfacing ease-of-use and perceived-ROI gaps that informed Google's SMB onboarding approach.
- Converted qualitative and quantitative consumer evidence into positioning recommendations, personas, journey maps, and product specifications that informed brand, innovation, and category-entry decisions.
- Caught a target-segment rejection of a proposed name in concept testing, prompting the client to revise it before launch.
- Managed 8+ concurrent projects with Excel-based data-collation structures, pivot tables, and Gantt charts; built client-ready PowerPoint narratives translating research into recommendations for senior stakeholders.

Research Associate Aug 2023 – Mar 2024

- Coordinated 13 research studies end-to-end, writing 4 recruitment questionnaires and adapting screening for 5+ studies.
- Co-moderated consumer research sessions for clients including Google AI/Bard and Cadbury Gems.

Consultant, Product Management & Brand Strategy June 2026 – Aug 2026

SWISSGEAR × Group III International

- Built a competitive whitespace framework across a ~\$19B U.S. core TAM using hypothesis-driven TAM/SAM/SOM sizing and a category PESTLE scan for SWISSGEAR's growth strategy.
- Fielded three consumer surveys (2,400 participants) to map brand-association tensions and define the client's right-to-play and right-to-win spaces; ran k-means segmentation in R on 800+ modular backpack respondents (K=4), identifying Modular Seekers (23%, highest intent, ~\$123 WTP) as the priority audience.
- Built an 8-criteria scoring framework with 1/3/5-year SOM projections across 7 whitespace concepts, sizing a \$36M year-five opportunity and delivering a go-to-market recommendation the client used to prioritize investment.
- Led client communication under NDA; scope expanded to independently developing the winning category's product brief.

Research Scholar Oct 2025 – Present

Northwestern Medill, Spiegel Research Center

- Selected as 1 of 6 scholars (of 120) to independently conduct phenomenological research (14 interviews, 10 countries); built a hierarchical coding schema translating findings into business implications.

Earlier Experience May 2021 – Apr 2023

- Data Visualization Intern, WageIndicator Foundation — 10+ Tableau visuals of labor data from 50+ countries, used in Annual Reports.
- Market Research Intern, Quantum Consumer Solutions — usage-and-attitudes study for YouTube ahead of Shorts India launch.

SKILLS

Business & Analytical Tools: Excel (pivot tables, Gantt charts, positioning maps), PowerPoint, Word, Canva

Strategic Analysis: TAM/SAM/SOM & whitespace mapping, PESTLE, Porter's Five Forces, hypothesis-driven problem solving

Qualitative Methods: In-depth interviews, ethnography, phenomenology, Zaltman Metaphor Elicitation, emic/etic coding

Research & Data: SPSS, STATA, R (k-means, logistic regression), Tableau, Qualtrics, thematic/hierarchical coding

Languages: English, Hindi, Marathi

Athletics: National-level competitive powerlifter (Bronze, National Championship 2023); multiple state and regional gold medals